weaken your position against Russia. The Afghans were neutral and would have received your aid against invaders with gratitude – they will now be disaffected and glad to join any invader that will drive you out.'[127]

Nor did the Company's local allies believe that the invasion would be at all easy. The Nawab of Bahawalpur, through whose territory the British troops would have to pass, expressed his deep anxieties, which were echoed by all his courtiers. As the British official sent to negotiate with him reported,

> They dwelt on the difficulties of the country, our ignorance of the road and the passes and what appeared to the British Government an easy enterprise, but which to their profound apprehension they said was beset with no ordinary difficulties. With respect to the Shah's fortune, their opinion was most unfavourable. With regard to Dost Muhammad Khan, the general opinion here seems to be that he will never be brought to sue for terms until everyone has deserted him and every door has been closed for him.[128]

When Burnes was summoned to give advice at the Governor General's Residence in Simla on 20 July, he was warned not to muddle Auckland or attempt to change his mind. According to Masson, 'when he arrived, Torrens and Colvin came running to him and prayed him to say nothing to unsettle his Lordship; that they had all the trouble in the world to get him into the business and that even now he would be glad of any pretext to retire from it'.[129] As late as August, Auckland was still oscillating between plans and examining all possible options.

Nonetheless, the pieces were now slowly falling into place, with the invasion plans driven forward relentlessly by Macnaghten and the hawks in the administration despite Auckland's anxieties and reservations.[130] Every day, the scale of the invasion and the degree of British participation gradually increased until a full 20,000 British troops were committed: the largest military operation undertaken by Company forces for two decades, and the first really major conflict since the defeat of Tipu Sultan forty years earlier.

On 10 September, the order for mobilisation was given: Lord Auckland formally asked his Commander-in-Chief to assemble an army for the march into Afghanistan. Across India, sleepy cantonments slowly began to stir into action. In Landour, Captain William Dennie scribbled in his diary: 'We are on the verge of something momentous. They say we are going to fight the Russians or Persians.'[131] The same day, Burnes was sent off to prepare a